

**Applicant Name:** David John Goeb

**Position:** Fixed-Term Instructor of English as a Foreign Language

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## **Essay 2: Alignment with Founder Hachisaburo Hirao's Educational Philosophy**

Konan University's founding vision, articulated by Hachisaburo Hirao, stands out in Japanese higher education for its commitment to whole-person development, respect for individuality, and practical contribution to society. As an educator whose practice is grounded in relational pedagogy, task-based learning, and student agency, Hirao's philosophy closely mirrors the core principles that guide my teaching and graduate research.

Hirao's belief in educating the whole person (*tokuiku*) fits naturally with my approach to classroom management and student engagement. In my graduate research at the University of Southern Maine, I conceptualized the learning environment as a living ecosystem: a space where intellectual growth cannot be separated from emotional safety, trust, and well-being. Throughout my teaching career in both the U.S. and Japan, I have prioritized building supportive classroom cultures where students feel valued as complete individuals. Whether facilitating advisory periods that promote belonging, integrating reflective practices to support student focus, or offering steady encouragement during office hours, I believe character development and emotional confidence are the true prerequisites for academic success.

In addition, Hirao's emphasis on respecting individuality aligns directly with my research on learner identity and *investment*. In the university EFL context, students arrive with vastly different motivations, background experiences, and future goals. Rather than applying a rigid, one-size-fits-all curriculum, I view my role as helping each student discover and cultivate their unique English-speaking voice. At Kindai University and KUAS, this meant scaffolding instruction to support diverse learning styles, guiding university-bound students through individual research projects, and advising learners on their personal study abroad and career ambitions. By recognizing each student's distinct "imagined identity," language learning transforms from a passive obligation into a deeply personal, empowering journey.

Finally, Hirao's commitment to practical education that serves real society directly informs my instructional design. Language education fulfills its purpose only when students can apply their skills beyond the classroom walls. In my courses, I emphasize communicative pragmatics, real-world task design, and collaborative problem-solving. My recent work developing digital learning frameworks centered on conversational nuance and everyday interactions reflects this same commitment: bridging academic theory with functional, real-world utility. By building collaborative group dynamics and peer dialogue in class, I prepare students to navigate

cross-cultural environments with empathy, confidence, and integrity.

If granted the opportunity to join Konan University, I look forward to honoring Hachisaburo Hirao's enduring legacy. By building an inclusive classroom ecosystem that balances academic rigor with character building, I aim to support Konan students as they grow into thoughtful, capable, and globally minded contributors to society.